



U.S. Highway 169 Corridor Coalition

Working together to enhance safety, reduce congestion and maximize economic development along the US Highway 169 inter-regional corridor.

www.us169corridorcoalition.com

LEGISLATIVE EVENT PRESENTATION OUTLINE

Thursday, March 6, 2014

Program at 7:30 a.m.

Note: Talking points are from the 2013 Legislative Breakfast

→ Welcome | **Commissioner Jon Ulrich**

→ Introductions

→ Presentation | **Legislative Committee**

- **Intro | Jon Ulrich**
 - This is our fifth legislative event since formally organizing as a coalition in 2009. We appreciate the legislative support.
- **About Us**
- **Membership**
 - Our membership consists of eleven cities, five counties, three townships and three gold, four silver, two bronze, and two individual level business associate members.
- **Mission and Objectives**
 - Note our mission: Working together to enhance safety, reduce congestion, and maximize economic development along the US Highway 169 inter-regional corridor.
 - Objective
- **MN Economy – Infographic**
 - The US 169 Corridor has significant economic importance for the State of Minnesota. As you can see, the Corridor fosters important factors to economic success currently and moving into the future.
 - The US 169 coalition formed to further advocate for transportation investment in the corridor. Our membership covers an 80 mile corridor from the 494 beltway in the twin cities to the Mankato area and then to points beyond in greater Minnesota. But our collaborative efforts have grown to include a strong desire to work together on economic development as well.
- **MN Economy – Supporting Efforts**
 - We are multi modal in nature-as a coalition we have strong interests and needs to work together for freight, rail, transit, pedestrians, recreational trails, and river crossings.
 - How important this highway is for our Communities. It is a lifeline that we need to for the economic vitality of our communities. US 169 is a corridor that moves agricultural commodities, manufacturing supplies and products, energy, commuters and it's the primary connection for southern Minnesota to the Twin Cities.
- **Northern Corridor Vision**
 - **Priorities and Successes**



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- I would like to point out the sheer number of projects in the both the northern and southern portions of the corridors whether it be completed, planned, proposed, or projects in progress.
- In 2002, Mn/DOT with local partners completed a corridor management plan for this High Priority Interregional corridor. In that plan, projects were identified as needs in the short and long term to ensure safety and mobility on the corridor. There have been many accomplishments – projects that have been completed include TH19 interchange, TH25 interchange in Belle Plaine, the award winning reconstruction of TH169 in downtown St Peter, and safety projects in Belle Plaine and Sand Creek Township.
- As transportation funding has tightened and the I35w bridge collapse has focused state attention away from these corridors that are the lifeline for many of our communities, we felt the need to unite together to bring attention to the needs of the corridors so that they are not forgot by the Mn/DOT and the state and regional officials that make transportation investment decisions.
- We are proud of our success as a coalition, the 494/169 interchange has been completed. For this we are thankful. This was unanimously the number one need by everyone up and down the corridor.
- While the other needs on the corridor dwarf the magnitude of the 494/169 project, through collaboration we have discovered the transportation related issues that we have in common and investment need to sustain our communities. We are now beginning to collaborate on transit, trails, rail, flood mitigation, and economic development.
- The TH41 and TH169 interchange is a truly needed interchange. Its one of only 2 principal arterial to principal arterial connections in the metro area that remains as an at-grade signalized intersection
- Yes we do have needs---we have identified 22 projects (3 have been funded- the CSAH 69 interchange on the south end of Shakopee, the TH 22 and the Highway 101 flood Mitigation projects) throughout the corridor.
- MnDOT has been a good partner up and down the corridor, but I would be remiss in saying that we do have concerns. Minnesota GO transportation vision and the MnSHP efforts seem to be focused on the funding situation of today, rather than planning for the future. A goal that focuses on planning for the future is important. Yes we know living within our means is a reality, but we are planning for our community's long term future, not just a fiscally constrained budget. To not have goals that we can collaborate on limits the opportunity.
- **Southern Corridor Vision | Commissioner Vance Stuehrenberg**
 - **Priorities and Successes**



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- We have reaffirmed they are all good worthwhile projects that deserve to remain in the plan-even though we acknowledge that some are long term. Of course some are more important to work on in the short term-
 - TH14 interchange in Mankato – we have some work to build consensus locally, but with the growth in the employment base this is an important project for us to work together with the DOT and develop the right sized project.
 - The LeSuer Hill Interchange project also will likely occur in phases but the need to get something moving to support the expansion of Cambria and other local employers is really important.
 - We have transit as a top priority in the corridor. We are happy to see the efforts that have been made to add park and ride spaces south of the Minnesota River in Scott County (built by the County with regional funding) (1300 spaces since 2007) and we look forward to the current effort underway by the Metropolitan Council to study the feasibility of a Highway Transitway on US169 in its system wide study. Expansion of express transit is an effective way to improve the through put of TH169. With all the employment on the corridor we are certain that it will show great promise to take advantage of the FTA small starts program and begin implementation of Bus Rapid Transit or some enhanced form of service.
 - The intercity commuter rail study also showed great promise for the Mankato to the Cities corridor but making that connection to Downtown Minneapolis will need some work
- **Legislative Platform**
 - As a Coalition, we have initiatives that align with our mission to reduce congestion, maximize economic development, and enhance safety along the Corridor that we support and advocate for. These programs are where we ask your attention and your support to be focused on regarding transportation in the corridor.
 - **Corridor Studies:** Support re-evaluation of the Hwy 169 IRC, and support funding for such IRC re-evaluations.
 - This reevaluation should build on the vision of the 2002 plans. There was a lot of community buy in that process. We don't need to start the process over or throw out the efforts. What is needed is prioritizing projects and looking interim solutions
 - **Multimodal:**
 - Support the evaluation of all transit options along the 169 corridor.
 - The Twin Cities Metro region has not been planning for a transit way corridor. Legislative support for these types of studies and coordination between metro areas are key to making proper transit investments to serve our future needs.



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- Multimodal: Support the evaluation of all bicycle and pedestrian options along the 169 corridor.
- **Transportation Funding:**
 - Funding should be continued for programs like CIMS, TED, SaM, and Corridors of Commerce programs.
 - Safety is a critical element of these IRC corridors like US 169. To really make a dent in the safety issues on high speed expresses, signals need to be removed and sometimes, although expensive an interchange is the right solution. In Scott County TH41 is a great example of an intersection that a low cost fix is not the right solution.
 - Local bridge and/or flood mitigation bonding is critical to reducing the impacts of flooding along the Minnesota River Valley, and by extension the Hwy. 169.
 - Mn/DOT has funded some of those needs but there are additional needs between St Peter and Mankato on TH 169. We have funded the projects that were low hanging fruit, but having infrastructure that is not flood prone is critical for economic development and the safety of our communities along the corridor.
 - Right-of-Way Acquisition Loan Fund (RALF) should be continued, and perhaps expanded for use in the Metropolitan Area.
 - The need to preserve r/w for future improvements is great. We ask the legislature to be careful in diverting funds from this program during times of funding shortages (recent diversion of funds to transit in Twin Cities metro area)
 - We support the continuation and funding of the Corridors of Commerce program.

- **Contact Us**

→ **Legislative Discussion | [Mayor Jim Hovland](#)**

→ **Network**